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What place can Purépecha play in young people's lives?

An exploratory study of domains of use, perceived barriers and youth perspective in a Purepecha community in Michoacán, México.

Introduction

This research was motivated by the researcher's observations within her own Purépecha community. As a community member and Purépecha speaker, she became increasingly concerned that many young people were no longer learning or using the language to the same extent as previous generations, raising questions about its future transmission. This local concern reflects a broader pattern of Indigenous language shift documented in many parts of the world, where reduced intergenerational transmission can gradually restrict the social presence and everyday use of minoritised languages. The study therefore emerged from a locally grounded concern: to better understand how young people in J. Jesús Díaz Tzirio currently relate to Purépecha and what this may mean for the language's continued presence in community life.

Research Objective

To understand how young people relate to Purépecha in their everyday lives and use their perspectives to inform future participatory initiatives that may expand opportunities for language use and contribute to efforts in the revitalisation of Purépecha.

Research Questions

1.- In which spaces, activities and forms of communication do young people consider Purépecha could have a greater presence in their everyday lives?
2. What linguistic, social and affective difficulties do young people identify in relation to learning and using Purépecha?
3. What themes, formats and forms of participation do young people favour for future initiatives aimed at expanding opportunities to use Purépecha?

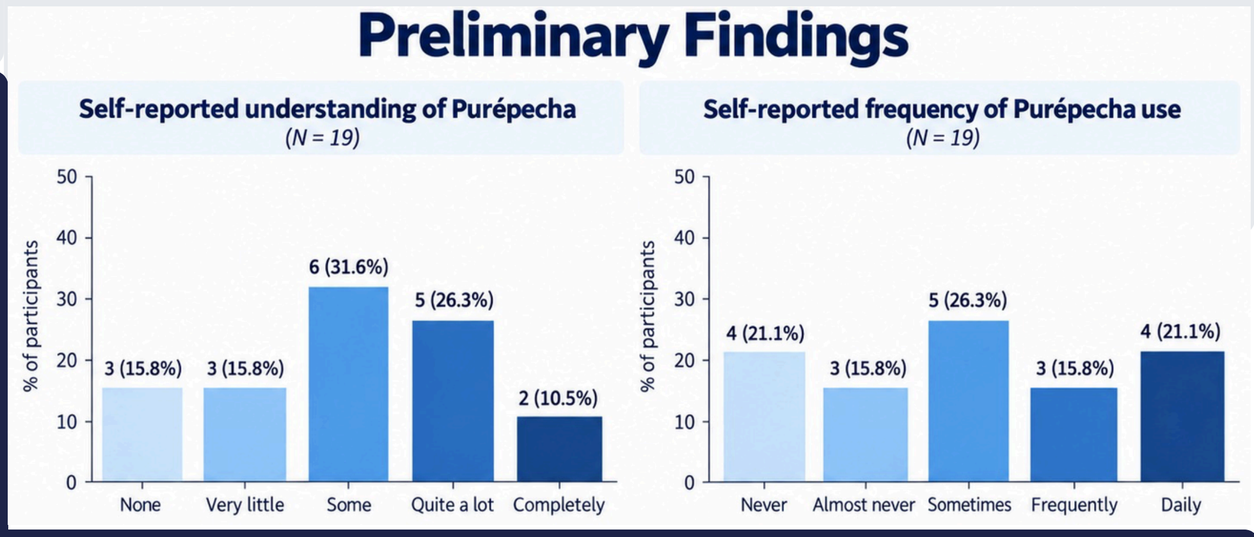
Methods

Design: Researcher-led exploratory case study incorporating participatory consultation.
Participants: N=19 students, 3rd year, aged 15–19, from Telebachillerato 140 in J. Jesús Díaz Tzirio, Michoacán.
Data collection: Exploratory questionnaire, participatory workshop, focus-group discussions and researcher field notes.
Analysis: Thematic analysis using inductive and deductive coding, informed by participants' accounts and the conceptual framework.
Ethics: Written informed consent from parents, students provided informed assent. Participants' identities were protected through anonymisation of research materials and reported findings.
Positionality: The researcher is a community member and Purépecha speaker; this supported contextual understanding while requiring reflexive attention to how this could shape interpretation.

Theoretical Framework

Language shift involves changes in intergenerational transmission, patterns of use and the social functions of a language. **Revitalisation** considers the conditions that may support its continued and meaningful use within community life (Córdova-Hernández, 2023).
Domains of language use can determine meaning and functionality of language through the contexts in which they are used, including the family, school, community, peer interaction (Fishman, 1972).
Language attitudes and affective factors in language use may be shaped by attitudes, confidence, embarrassment, perceived competence and fear of judgement, which can influence speakers' willingness to use a minoritised language (Garrett, 2010).
Youth agency and participatory consultation emphasises young people are social actors whose experiences, priorities and perspectives can inform future initiatives, while requiring attention to researcher–participant power relations (Kustatscher et al., 2022).
Digital practices are considered a possible contemporary domain of language use, particularly for younger generations, rather than a predetermined solution to language revitalisation (Galla, 2018).

Preliminary Findings



Discussion

Participants reported diverse linguistic profiles, suggesting that young people should not be treated as a homogeneous group in terms of Purépecha knowledge or use.
Difficulties associated with active use included pronunciation, vocabulary and comprehension, alongside affective factors such as embarrassment and insecurity.
Young people proposed combining cultural and community-based content with formats such as music, humour, short videos and social media.
Responses highlighted youth agency in decisions about whose perspective, what and how it should be represented.

Limitations and Next Steps

Small, context-specific sample and self-reported data limit generalisation. Next, complete the thematic analysis, share findings with participants, and use their priorities to guide future material's co-design participatory workshops.

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